How to Write a Fairytale

By Cora Sorenson

Location: *Top of the Golden Gate Bridge*

SEQUOIA: **(Pgs 29-33)** *(age 17; direct but contemplative; vulnerable but guarded) (to audience)* I totally did not expect for it to be this cold up here. I'm like, freezing my a** off, ya know? I mean I would have brought a sweater or something if I'd known. So . . . umm . . . anyway, my point is that people and things are rarely, like, if ever exactly as they seem.

So, like, Jesus and I have been on speaking terms for years. I mean, of course, we fight as good friends tend to do, but I like to think that we always make up before bedtime. It was Grandma Rose who taught me about getting up close and personal with Jesus when I was like, I dunno, probably like six. Grandma Rose was one of the first foster parents I ever had. She died three days before my ninth birthday, when she spoke to me it was like her voice was going through some kind of weird machine. "Your heart knows where it must go, Sequoia. You know everything that's true." That was the last time I cried.

INTRODUCTION

According to the CDC, approximately 1 in 4 girls and 1 in 20 boys in the United States are victims of sexual abuse before the age of 18 (Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, 2024), and most of them know the person who hurt them. Most of them are told it's love. Most of them are told to stay quiet.*

Sequoiah is 17 years old and standing at the edge of the world. She has tried building her fairy tale out of foster homes and occasional trips for ice cream. She has tried to recognize her life as a 'blessing'. But she's come to realize a devastating truth: people and things are rarely, if ever, what they seem. Her life is not a fairy tale – and there is no knight in shining armor in her story. Not even Jesus will save her from the wolves.

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SEQUOIA: I was a little bouncing ball for the next three years, until I was like, about twelve, I guess. So, it was sort of like I'd hooked up with Jesus' personal fax line or something when I got placed with the DeWitts, right? The DeWitts were mid-thirties; she was a teacher, he was some kind of business something-or-other. They lived like two hours away from San

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Francisco, nice house. Interesting developments for my fairy tale, you know? We celebrated "my placement" by going to a Farley's ice cream parlor and I ate three scoops of lemon custard ice cream. They had put a huge framed picture of a Sequoia redwood tree in my new bedroom. I liked them . . . for a little while.

But then Mr. DeWitt celebrated "my placement" two months later by coming into my bedroom and doing disgusting things to me. His hand under my nightgown was at first ice cold and then as hot as an iron brand. And me, I thought, of course, that I had to nightmare-ing something terrible, right? That Grandma Rose had just told me one too many real fairy tales and that this particular night terror was just too bad that it felt real. So I blinked my eyes, right? Once, twice, thrice, here Dorothy clicks her ruby slippers until she finds herself at home, sleeping soundly. No such luck, little shrub girl. No such happy endings for you, silly girl. So, I keep blinking and his hand is still there, now as red hot as I'd think a cattle prod to be. And I'm thinking, I should have gotten Jesus on speed dial or something, because I'm praying. "Please don't hurt me like this," because now it's actually hurting my body and I'm fighting as hard as I can to push and get up, but with his other hand he shoves me down so hard, I'm afraid I won't be able to find my breath at all, right? Not at all, and then for a few seconds I fear that I'm not breathing, that I'm going to die right there in that bed with my Mr. DeWitt branding me like a cow with his red-hot touch, and I'm waiting to see the aliens with their yellow lights. But I didn't die, and Mr. DeWitt keeps at it, until whatever he'd hoped to happen happens and then he's gone. No words, just gone. And I'm changed, bruised permanent, I guess. Branded. Yeah.

So, I didn't tell anyone until I met Rusty. Well, not met Rusty, because we didn't actually meet until just a few days ago. But when I first encountered Rusty, I'd stay up late – chatting on the 'net, and that's how I found him. Rusty told me that he was my age and lived in San Francisco. We chatted for hours about everything. So, I told him about Mr. DeWitt and he told me that things were going to be okay. Fairy tale ending. Yeah. It was months before he agreed to send a picture of himself. But when he did . . . well, teenage angst or not, a hot boy is a hot boy. Dark eyes, dark hair, good stuff. It wasn't that, though,

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seriously. I couldn't even really think of that. It was just . . . having somebody who would listen. So, we're talking, going on two years of chatting with Rusty every single night. And he finally agrees to meet me at this little sushi bar in the city. I'm gonna go, and, umm, things are gonna change.

So, umm, three days ago I took Mrs. DeWitt's Chase Platinum and got on a Greyhound to make the trip. And so, I got here, to the city at, like, six thirty or so . . . and I was supposed to meet Rusty at seven. So I wandered around until I found the place, and I walked in, and I waited. And well, like a half hour later, this guy comes over to me, and he says, "Sequoia? And umm, you know what was really strange about this? This guy, well, he says, "I'm Rusty" and well, what's really frickin' strange is that this guy doesn't have dark hair at all. No . . . umm, his hair is blonde. And this guy, well, this guy has strange grey blue eyes, like the ocean. And umm, the weirdest frickin' thing of all is that this guy is like, well, he's like, I dunno, forty years old. Yeah, that's right. Weird, huh? And, uh, this is Rusty. It is. And, of course, he starts apologizing almost immediately. Explaining, that he couldn't, uh, explain until I met him.

The next thing I knew, I'm going back to his room with him. Back with Rusty to this fancy hotel where they don't even look twice in the lobby. So, we get up to this huge big room with paintings and lights and a big bathtub that you can walk right into. And uh, Rusty tells me that he loves me. Right. And uh, apparently, to talk. He brought along this bag of stuff . . . all kinds of things, I didn't even know what some of it was. This was, of course, like, only if I wanted to. And um, my body is just like hot ice at this point. I'm just burning up through my skin, but I find what I need. It's, uh, this little silky blind fold. And Rusty, whaever, is sitting on the edge of the bed, an so I take this little blind-fold thing and I tie it around Rusty's head. And he's saying, "Oh, Sequoia, what's next?" And me, I'm just full of fire, and it's like there's a herd of cattle or something stampeding through that hotel room, and I'm thinking, "Yeah, what's next for you, fair sir?" And um, I knew that I just had one good chance, ya know? Just one, for sure one, but I didn't realize that those hotel telephones are that heavy. But as quiet as I could, I unplugged the thing from the wall and, well, I brought

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it down as hard as I could on Rusty's head. And um, for as hard as heads are, it gave way so easy, like, umm, rotted fruit or something. And he didn't come back up really, I guess I heard like a bubbling sort of sound and so I just brought it up and down up and down up and down a bunch of times and then there was this big quiet all around us. A gigantic quiet, and I was just all bathed in red, and umm, Rusty was very still. And somebody was talking there. Grandma Rose or someone, maybe Jesus, I guess. "Your heart knows where it must go, Sequoia." I really didn't have much to say back, ya know? And I knew that Rusty wouldn't be getting on-line again anytime soon. I went and I showered and I walked out of the room and I, uh, I left the hotel.

People and things are usually not exactly as they seem. Have you seen that actor? Emile Hirsch? Cute, dark hair, yadda yadda. Rusty sent me a picture of Emile Hirsch. Did he think I was stupid? Ha. I knew. I knew before I ever left. Yeah. So um, sometimes there's fairytales and sometimes there's just crap, right? So, um, you kind of learn stuff when you spend hours alone on the internet. And one thing I learned was how to open up file indexes when people send you crap. So I got Rusty to email me more pictures, right? And the fourth or fifth time it was from a file where there were pictures of him and his wife and his kids . . . his, uh, his teenage daughter. Her name is Rose. I wonder how hot she feels sometimes. Sometimes you just do what you gotta do. Yeah. So, uh, one of the interesting facts I learned was that, last year, 47 people committed suicide by jumping from up here. On the Golden Gate Bridge. You see, I can't seem to reach Jesus at all these days. I don't have any frickin' clue what the business plan is for me at this point. Who is supposed to be saving who?

(shifts to directly addressing Jesus) Hello? Frickin', hello? If you're talking, I have no frickin' idea what you're sayin' there, buddy. . . seriously?

(to audience) How many trials? Wasps? Scorpions? I burn and then I . . . well, then I forget. When there's nothing worth remembering, it kinda gets a little tough to figure out the point, ya know? *(to Jesus)* Don't you remember? I'm six, kneeling by my bed, chatting with

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you like we're old friends? But then you failed to bring my Mommy back. How hard do I have to hurt? How faithful did you expect me to be? *(to audience)* Only 18 have jumped this year. I'd be 19. If a Sequoia tree falls in the great Pacific and no one hears it, does it still make a sound? Do you hear me? Can you answer? Can anyone?

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2014 National Qualifier
2025 National Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier
OH State Qualifier

Introduction Source Information
*** https://www.cdc.gov/child-abuse-neglect/about/about-child-sexual-abuse.html***

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